election without the loss of a single contesting candidate, a remarkable feat given that terrorists had killed scores of candidates and supporters in the run-up to the June 1991 polls, forcing them to be countermanded altogether.

When Beant Singh became chief minister in 1992, he was given a clear directive by then prime minister P.V. Narasimha Rao that there would be zero political meddling with the police. Gill began by lifting the force's morale, promoting and rewarding officers who showed promise and fearlessness in the face of extremism. Police who had for years grown used to withdrawing into their stations after dusk suddenly began dominating the hinterland at night. A key Gill innovation, Operation Night Dominance, saw the DGP himself out in the field; though it was army troops who actually laid the cordons in villages, photographs of Gill and his men in what had until then been terrorist bastions appeared in every newspaper, significantly demoralising terrorist cadres who now found it difficult, even impossible, to move around after dark.

By 1994, the number of civilians killed by terrorists was down to two, with no security personnel lost. Gill never acknowledged extra-judicial killings by his force, maintaining that Khalra was not wanted in any case and was never in police custody. He also stood by Ajit Singh Sandhu, the SSP at Tarn Taran, despite mounting allegations—noting only that Sandhu had not hesitated to take on a posting no other officer would accept. In his book, Gill alludes to his approach: "The 'liberal' mind has always remained ambivalent when confronted by the fact that the State, among other things, is a coercive instrument, and that it must, from time to time, exercise its option of the use of force—albeit judicious, narrowly defined and very specifically targeted use of force—if it is not to be overwhelmed by the greater violence of the enemies of freedom, democracy and lawful governance."

Six days after Beant Singh's assassination on August 31, 1995, Khalra was abducted from his Amritsar home on September 6, and brutally tortured before eventually being killed in illegal police custody. His body, unceremoniously consigned to the swirling waters of the Sutlej at the Harike Barrage, was never found. Nine rogue policemen, including the then SSP of Tarn Taran, were indicted in the case. Sandhu, who was already being prosecuted by the CBI in other cases of disappearances, ended his life under a speeding train outside Chandigarh in May 1997; eight of his co-accused were handed life sentences. While *Satluj* depicts Khalra's trial accurately, its flaw is that it makes no mention of his

WHILE *SATLUJ* PAINTS HIM AS A BUTCHER, K.P.S. GILL DID OVERSEE THE 1992 POLLS, SANS INCIDENT. JUST A YEAR EARLIER, THE ELECTION WAS COUNTERMANDED DUE TO TERRORIST VIOLENCE

POLITICAL FLASHPOINT

The film has turned Punjab's contested past into an electoral issue for the assembly polls early next year

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

***Satluj* never got a proper theatrical release, yet it has become one of the most politically charged cultural events Punjab has seen in years. The Bhagwant Mann government is already locked in one of its sharpest confrontations with the Akal Takht since the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) came to power in 2022. What began as a dispute over the state's anti-sacrilege law has grown into a larger contest over who speaks for Punjab's Sikhs—an elected government or the faith's highest temporal authority. The Akal Takht has excommunicated Mann over a separate controversial video, summoned Sikh ministers and legislators to explain the government's stand on the law, and asked the state to revisit it.**

***Satluj* landed in the middle of that battle, with the assembly election just seven months away. On July 14, Akal Takht acting *jathedar* Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj led an *ardaas* (prayer) at Harike Pattan, where the Sutlej meets the Beas, for Jaswant Singh Khalra and victims of alleged fake encounters.**

For AAP right now, silence seems to be the safest zone. By avoiding a firm public position on the film, Mann risks alienating neither Sikh religious opinion nor Hindu voters. But if the debate shifts towards militant violence and the victims of terrorism, the party could come under growing pressure from moderate Sikh and Hindu voters seeking a clearer statement of where the government stands.

For the Congress, already mired in factional infighting, the deeper problem is historical. The party still carries the baggage of Operation Bluestar and its aftermath, making any move into the terrain of Sikh grievance far more fraught than it is for its rivals. So, it too has opted to keep a low profile.